

Braided Research for at least Two (2) Stories

Essay

I reached for my pocket to find a used and dried 15mg nicotine pouch, measly 82 cents, and an advertisement for a halloween funhouse I got handed by a guy dressed like a zombie in mid July. All in that order.

I do the pocket search dance with a small heart attack while the barista pulls my daily six shots of their medium roast in a sugarless americano. The wallet, nowhere to be found, was probably dreaming about storing the money of an outlaw's bounty (hunted in the wild west fashion) or at least some genre of epic that includes being filled with treasures. All while laying in my unwashed pants from the night before.

In my head, there must exist some unobserved God who likes to play out small inconveniences to hold back the withdrawal symptoms from the lack of Greek adventures that the modern days present. Something like sliding his hand into one unassuming subject's pocket and flying their keys back into their car, then he goes back into his office and plans the next strike while listening to Take Five. So I damned that God, there wasn't a wallet anywhere a wallet could be.

In cases like this, the primal survival instincts developed by our ancestors have abstracted fight or flight to the much less convenient frown or fright, but that special morning the thick cream of espresso smelled much like my deceased grandmother's home. So I did the next best thing and

zoned out while staring uncomfortably at a college freshman blonde dressed like a mix of every Quentin Tarantino character.

Back then I was 5 or 6 years young, blindly experiencing dad's job crisis which landed us on relying on my maternal grandma's support in Mexico. Living in her home where, once, the usual "instant coffee and assorted cookies" themed gossip session between my mom and my grandma would be interrupted by the knocks of a weeping man.

The northern region of Mexico is home primarily to the jaguar and the puma, both classified by their respective regional subspecies. However, no particular part of Mexico is naturally nesting a population of tigers and lions, which are classified in the "Old World Species". The soil and ecosystem that varies from desert to beaches, and arid plateau to forests allows for the perfect condition to look for your relative's corpses, conveniently bagged occasionally. The madres buscadoras (searching mothers, or searching moms) collective of Sonora has localized roughly 1230 dead bodies throughout Sonora, Sinaloa, and Jalisco, through a three to four day process of regional research, and a more extended process of geological forensics, including looking for uneven patches of dirt, sinks, and features of the soil which would indicate an underlying rot.

I remember my mother holding me to lock me in the room where I had all of my toys spare through the floor. Historically, it is a bad idea to hold a kid back without explaining the reasoning for it. Most children, even those who disappear, are curious by nature and will instead fight back a command with unsupervised eavesdropping of adult conversations. This is a tale as old as time. So in the face of being bored by the new series of McDonald's toys, I rumaged through a

conversation I didn't have the brains to understand whatsoever, I only knew that it smelled like instant coffee, and a man was crying for his life, and for his family: his son was dead. This was probably one of my first attempts at ever so slightly pondering about mortality.

In my personal defense, back then I was still at the works of reciting the primary colors to my teachers in English and making an inhumane attempt to not pee in long car rides.

One of the reasons to not want to pee on long car rides is exactly because all car rides are long in Mexico, at least when riding from city to city. That is because, truly, the infrastructure of Mexican roads is generally bad, with a score of 4.19 average on a scale of 1 to 7 (given by The Global Economy on a 2006 to 2019 database), which is no surprise to the population given that most of their tax money is being diverted for personal gain, as it was clearly seen in Enrique Peña Nieto's "master scam".

To make matters worse, the aesthetic composition of this infrastructure is devastating to the natural beauty of the Mexican landscape. With a strike of luck, a long distance driver may be able to find the severed bodies of journalists hanging from bridges in the roads, a trendy cartel solution in the feng shui of ecosystems decaying due to international company investment in dropping minerals into fresh water rivers. Matter of fact, the committee to protect Journalists has recorded a total of 166 killings of journalists and media workers related to cartels and organized crime in Mexico. It is no surprise that a child may want to pee in the road.

The man in my grandma's home wanted to talk to somebody about getting blackmailed by the cartel who had threatened to kill his daughter and wife if he continued protesting the death of

his son. Who had been killed after a miscommunication in a club, where he had flirted with the girlfriend of a cartel member. Leading up with his abduction and disappearance.

Based on hearsay and research, the father's investigation of his son's disappearance had him face to face with some members who explicitly claimed having fed him to the lions.

He, whose name I still don't know, was probably a man like many more: going out on a Tuesday night to get a few beers with his friends, owing his mom a phone call every once in a while, never having a real reason to think about lions.

But unlike me, his wallet wasn't waiting with ambition in a pile of trashy clothes, his wallet wasn't found anywhere.

I snap out of my confusion. The barista notices the nauseated look in my eyes thinking that all along, I was scared of forgetting a wallet, so she offers the coffee on the house since I'm a common customer. I went back to tip her \$10.82.

On the stories:

A few months ago I forgot my wallet in the pants I had used the night before right after I had ordered a coffee, which was already in the making.

Once when I was a child I eavesdropped on a conversation between my grandma and mom with a stranger who had come in crying. Later in life I learnt that this man's son was murdered in the

attempt to flirt with the couple of a notable cartel member, who allegedly, had been fed to the pet lions of the cartel members. The later protests from the man in question earned him threats of murdering his wife, and daughters if he continued.

Due to the sensitive nature of this topic, I would like to ask for discretion in what I share in this essay. Specifically because protesting and journaling of these topics can have severe consequences.